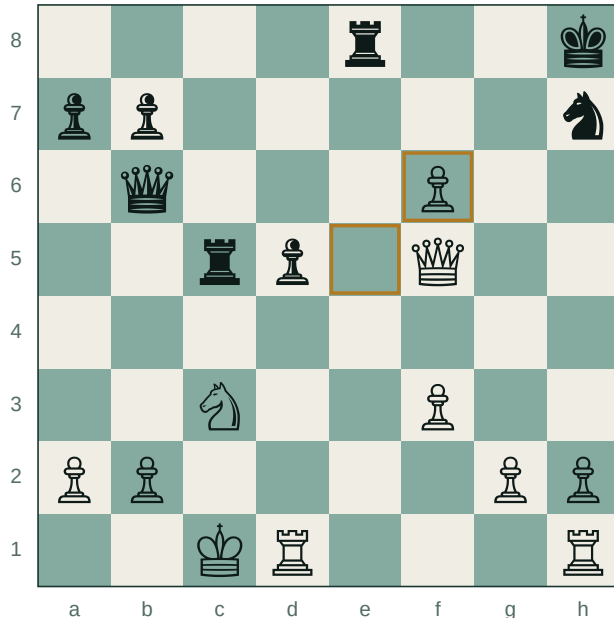


Queenside attacks: Black, move 26

Queenside attacks

Black to move



Previous move: 26.exf6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26...Re2 27. Qc2 Rxc2+

26...Re2 The rook moves from e8 to e2. Recorded reply: **27.Qc2**.

27...Rxc2+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. From c2 it attacks king on c1 and knight on c3.

At the end, nominal material is White 19 / Black 25 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +9. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +9: the balance goes from -3 to +6. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The board's left half is not inherently safe. Queen checks and rook entries can make a queenside king as vulnerable as a kingside one.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An attack on the queenside can target a castled king, a vulnerable pawn, or trapped pieces. Files and entry squares matter more than simply advancing flank pawns.

HOW TO LOOK

Locate the critical target and which pawn or piece move opens a route toward it. Check whether central counterplay interrupts the plan.

The defending king is on c1. Absolute pin: knight on c3.